

15

When to Change the Structure

c3-d4, c4 pressure, and central exchanges: leaving the standard shell at the right moment.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will know when a neighboring Réti, Closed Sicilian, or reversed king-pawn structure gives White the better practical game.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate White's candidates, find Black's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 085 | PAGE 4

Decode: The c3-d4 transformation*Prepare a break by improving the position after every likely recapture.*

LESSON 086 | PAGE 8

Play: The c3-d4 transformation*Prepare a break by improving the position after every likely recapture.*

LESSON 087 | PAGE 12

Decode: Switching to c4 pressure*A structural switch is good only when you know the opponent's most ambitious reply.*

LESSON 088 | PAGE 16

Play: Switching to c4 pressure*A structural switch is good only when you know the opponent's most ambitious reply.*

LESSON 089 | PAGE 20

Decode: Opening with exd5*When the center changes, keep the active recapture, not the old opening picture.*

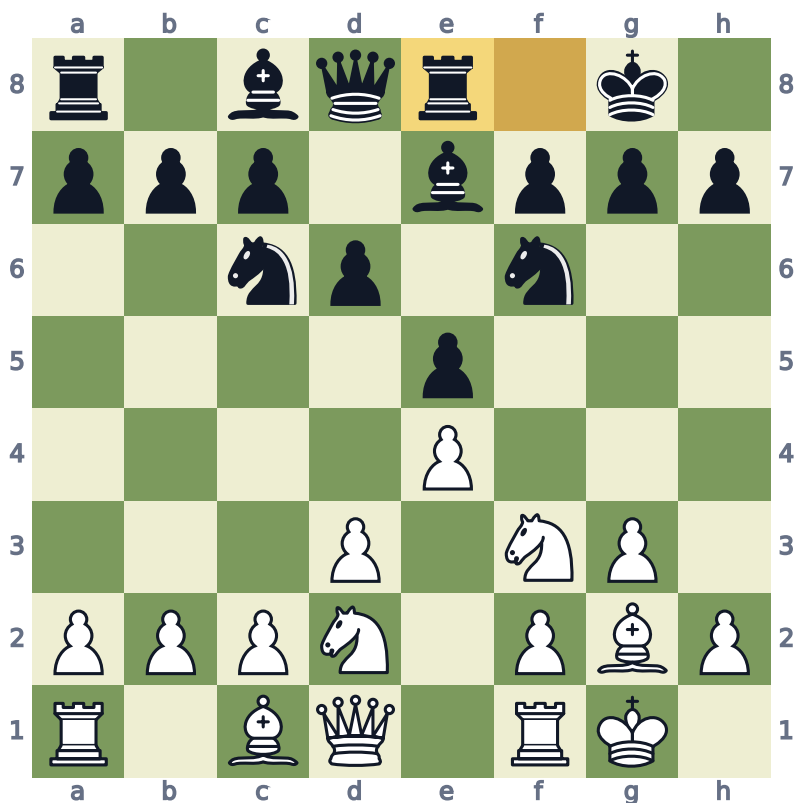
LESSON 090 | PAGE 24

Play: Opening with exd5*When the center changes, keep the active recapture, not the old opening picture.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will know when a neighboring Réti, Closed Sicilian, or reversed king-pawn structure gives White the better practical game.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The c3-d4 transformation



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

c3-d4 challenges Black's e5 center and can release the g2 bishop, turning slow maneuvering into an open central game.

DECISION RULE

After d4, which pawn recapture keeps White's center coherent and which black piece gains a square?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black maintains tension, exchanges on d4, or plays ...d5 if the resulting activity equalizes.

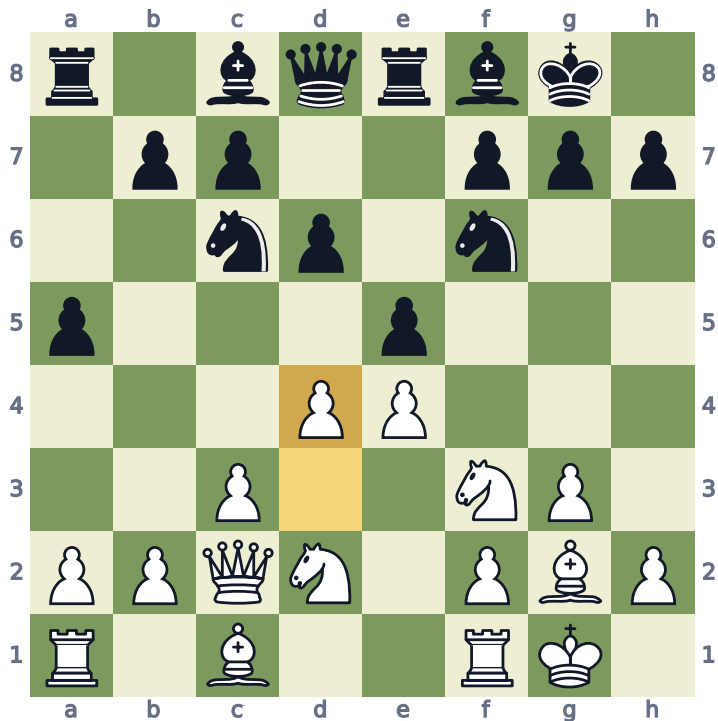
WHITE'S PLAN

White prepares d4 until the recapture develops a piece or opens the e-file on favorable terms.

MEMORY RULE | Prepare a break by improving the position after every likely recapture.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

c3-d4 challenges Black's e5 center and can release the g2 bishop, turning slow maneuvering into an open central game.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black maintains tension, exchanges on d4, or plays ...d5 if the resulting activity equalizes.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White prepares d4 until the recapture develops a piece or opens the e-file on favorable terms.

FAILURE MODE

Playing d4 merely because preparation is complete while the resulting exchanges favor Black.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After d4, which pawn recapture keeps White's center coherent and which black piece gains a square? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

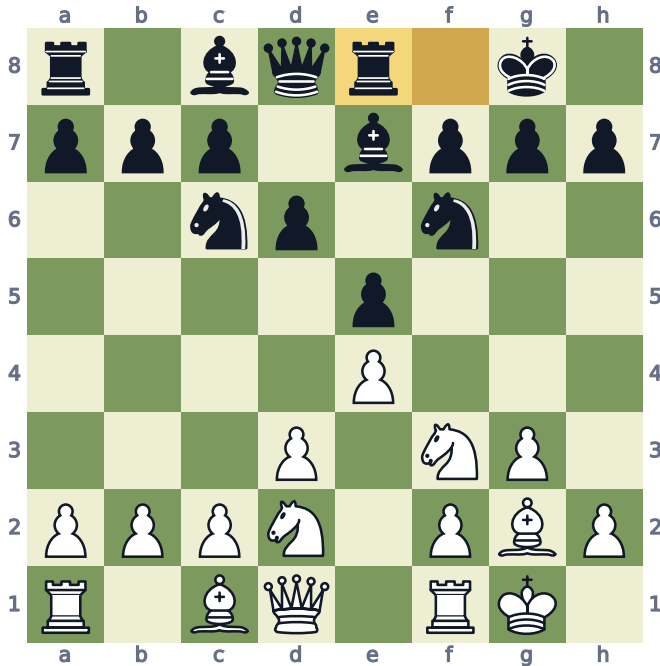
RULE | Prepare a break by improving the position after every likely recapture.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d6 2. g3 e5 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 Nc6 7. e4 Re8 8. c3 Bf8 9. Qc2 a5 10. d4



- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- e4: White builds the KIA center but must account for Black's immediate central break.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

c3-d4 challenges Black's e5 center and can release the g2 bishop, turning slow maneuvering into an open central game.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After d4, which pawn recapture keeps White's center coherent and which black piece gains a square? White's attacking or positional plan is: White prepares d4 until the recapture develops a piece or opens the e-file on favorable terms. The line fails as a template when: Playing d4 merely because preparation is complete while the resulting exchanges favor Black.

STORE THIS | Prepare a break by improving the position after every likely recapture.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

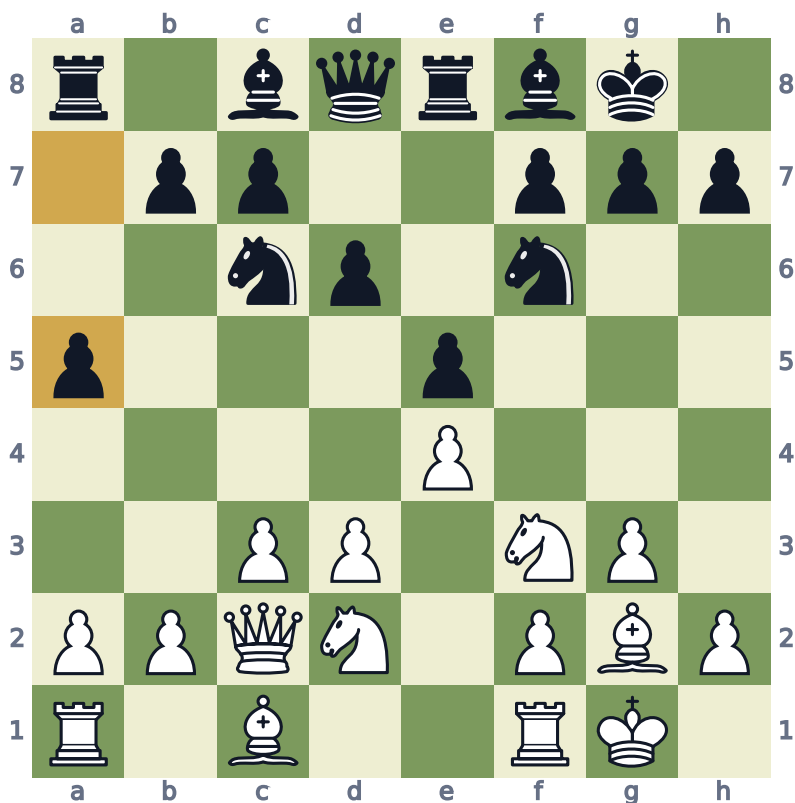
1. c3-d4 challenges Black's e5 center and can release the g2 bishop, turning slow maneuvering into an open central game. 2. Black maintains tension, exchanges on d4, or plays ...d5 if the resulting activity equalizes. 3. White prepares d4 until the recapture develops a piece or opens the e-file on favorable terms. 4. After d4, which pawn recapture keeps White's center coherent and which black piece gains a square? 5. Playing d4 merely because preparation is complete while the resulting exchanges favor Black.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 Nc6 7. e4 Re8

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The c3-d4 transformation



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

c3-d4 challenges Black's e5 center and can release the g2 bishop, turning slow maneuvering into an open central game.

DECISION RULE

After d4, which pawn recapture keeps White's center coherent and which black piece gains a square?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black maintains tension, exchanges on d4, or plays ...d5 if the resulting activity equalizes.

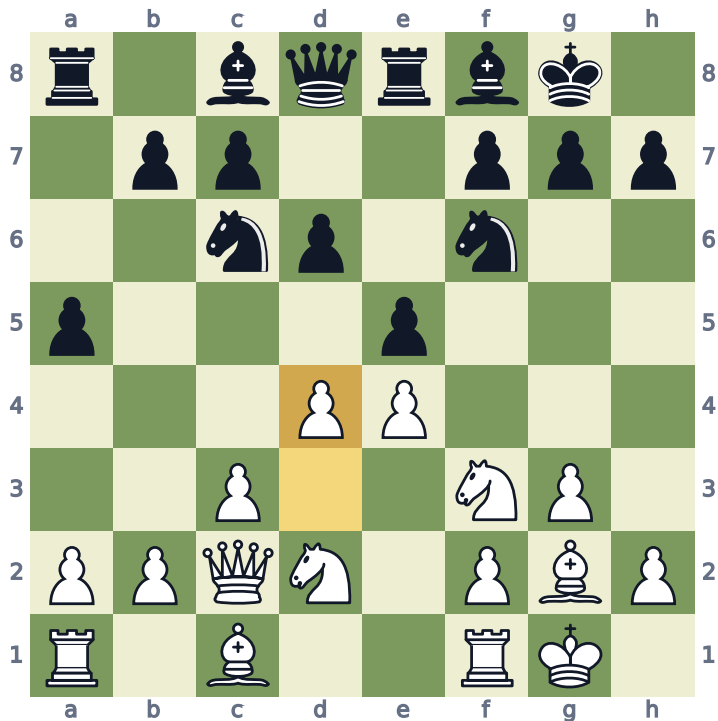
WHITE'S PLAN

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MEMORY RULE | Prepare a break by improving the position after every likely recapture.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

c3-d4 challenges Black's e5 center and can release the g2 bishop, turning slow maneuvering into an open central game.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black maintains tension, exchanges on d4, or plays ...d5 if the resulting activity equalizes.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White prepares d4 until the recapture develops a piece or opens the e-file on favorable terms.

FAILURE MODE

Playing d4 merely because preparation is complete while the resulting exchanges favor Black.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After d4, which pawn recapture keeps White's center coherent and which black piece gains a square? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

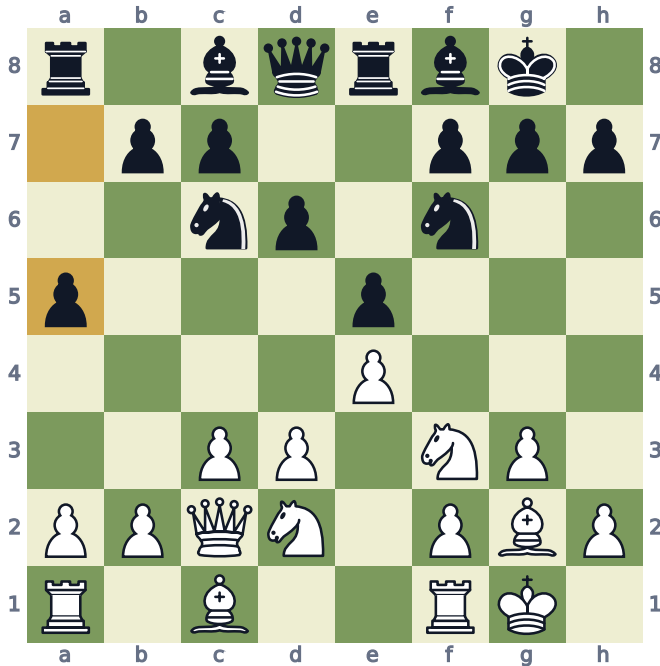
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- e4: White builds the KIA center but must account for Black's immediate central break.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- c3: White restrains d4 and prepares a central d4 break.
- Bf8: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- Qc2: White coordinates center and wing plans, but must check whether the queen becomes a tempo target.
- a5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

c3-d4 challenges Black's e5 center and can release the g2 bishop, turning slow maneuvering into an open central game.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After d4, which pawn recapture keeps White's center coherent and which black piece gains a square? White's attacking or positional plan is: White prepares d4 until the recapture develops a piece or opens the e-file on favorable terms. The line fails as a template when: Playing d4 merely because preparation is complete while the resulting exchanges favor Black.

STORE THIS | Prepare a break by improving the position after every likely recapture.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

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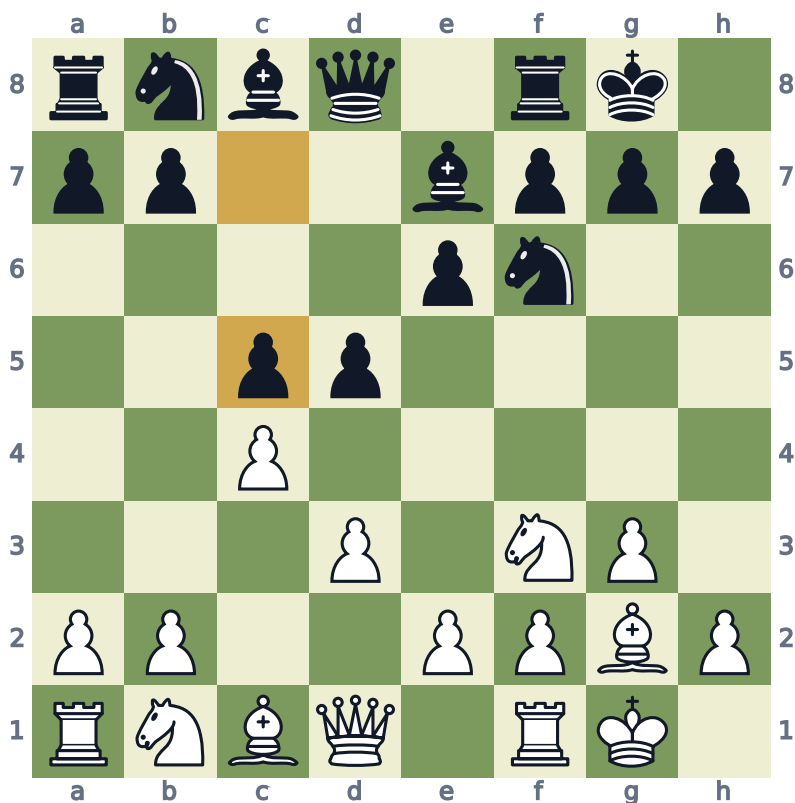
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. e4 Re8 8. c3 Bf8 9. Qc2 a5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Switching to c4 pressure

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

c4 attacks d5 and may create a Réti or reversed Benoni structure where the g2 bishop and queenside pressure matter more than a kingside pawn storm.

DECISION RULE

If Black plays ...d4, what break attacks the chain's base and where will the b1 knight develop?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black gains space with ...d4 and uses the center to restrict White's knights.

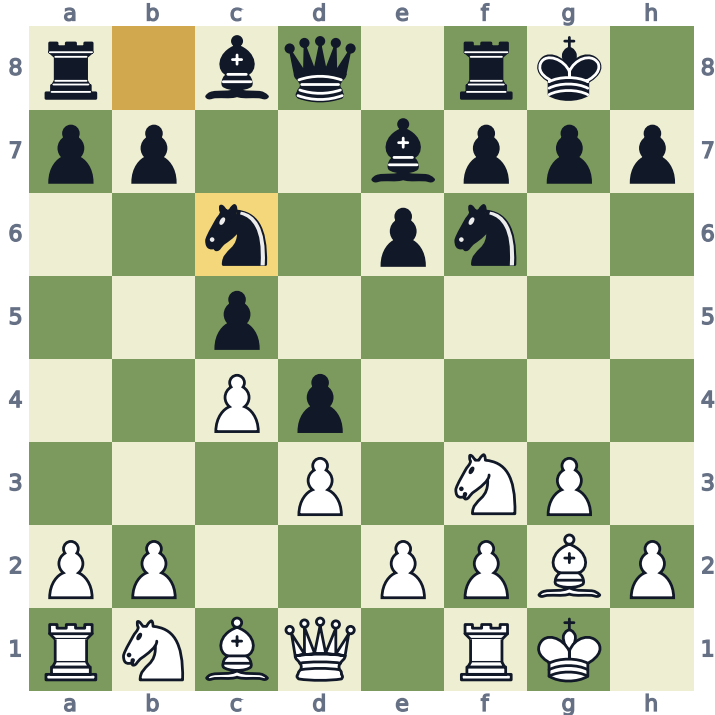
WHITE'S PLAN

White undermines the chain with e3, b4, or e4 and reroutes the displaced knight toward useful squares.

MEMORY RULE | A structural switch is good only when you know the opponent's most ambitious reply.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

c4 attacks d5 and may create a Réti or reversed Benoni structure where the g2 bishop and queenside pressure matter more than a kingside pawn storm.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black gains space with ...d4 and uses the center to restrict White's knights.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White undermines the chain with e3, b4, or e4 and reroutes the displaced knight toward useful squares.

FAILURE MODE

Switching to c4 without accepting the strategic work required after ...d4.

DECISION TEST

Ask: If Black plays ...d4, what break attacks the chain's base and where will the b1 knight develop? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

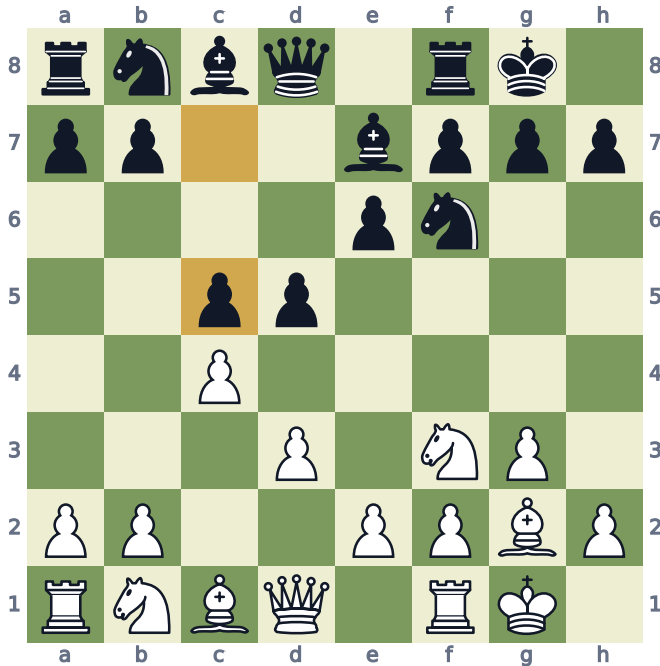
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. c4 c5 7. Nc3 d4 8. Nb1 Nc6



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- c4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- c5: Black attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

c4 attacks d5 and may create a Réti or reversed Benoni structure where the g2 bishop and queenside pressure matter more than a kingside pawn storm.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

If Black plays ...d4, what break attacks the chain's base and where will the b1 knight develop? White's attacking or positional plan is: White undermines the chain with e3, b4, or e4 and reroutes the displaced knight toward useful squares. The line fails as a template when: Switching to c4 without accepting the strategic work required after ...d4.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

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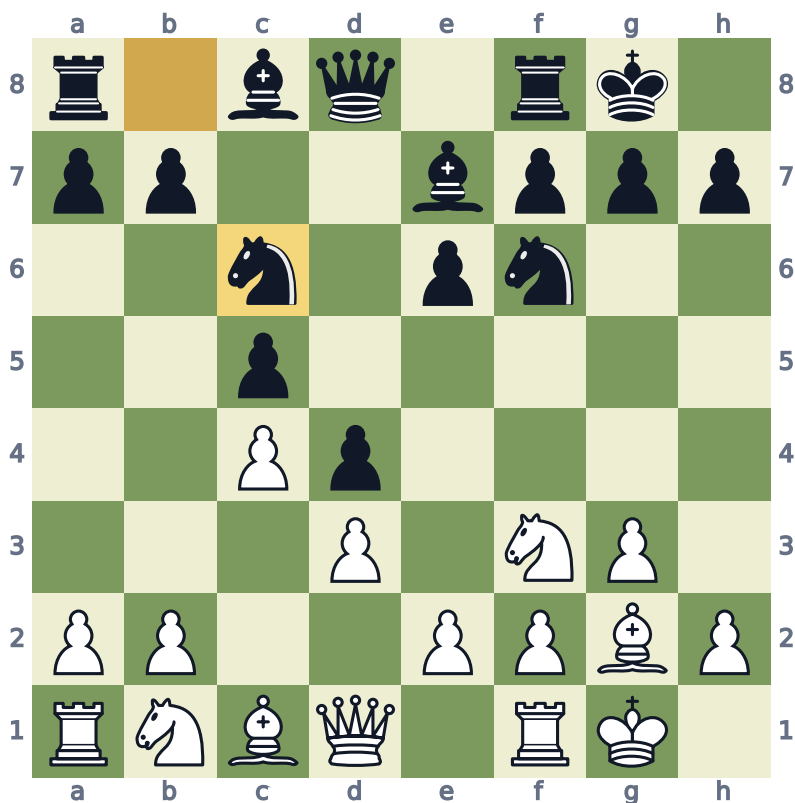
1. c4 attacks d5 and may create a Réti or reversed Benoni structure where the g2 bishop and queenside pressure matter more than a kingside pawn storm. 2. Black gains space with ...d4 and uses the center to restrict White's knights. 3. White undermines the chain with e3, b4, or e4 and reroutes the displaced knight toward useful squares. 4. If Black plays ...d4, what break attacks the chain's base and where will the b1 knight develop? 5. Switching to c4 without accepting the strategic work required after ...d4.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. c4 c5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Switching to c4 pressure



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

c4 attacks d5 and may create a Réti or reversed Benoni structure where the g2 bishop and queenside pressure matter more than a kingside pawn storm.

DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

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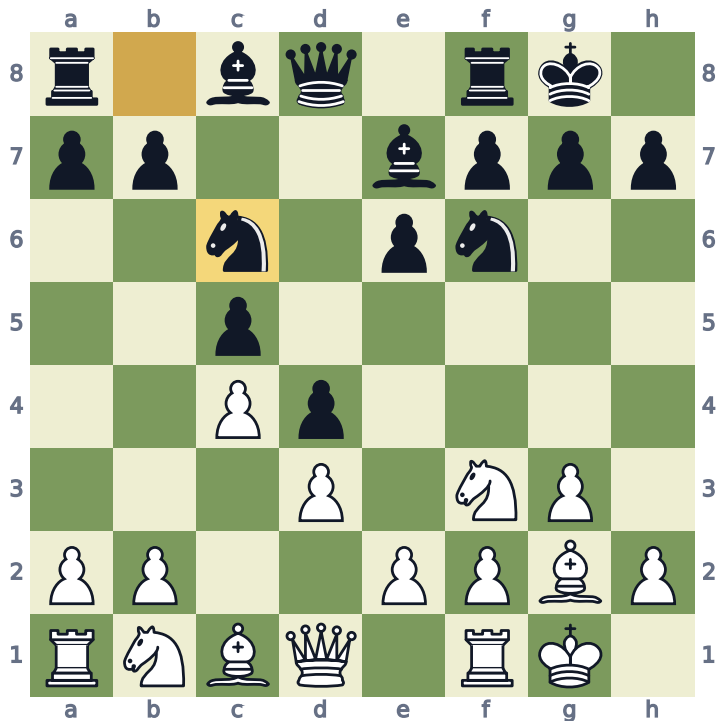
WHITE'S PLAN

White undermines the chain with e3, b4, or e4 and reroutes the displaced knight toward useful squares.

MEMORY RULE | A structural switch is good only when you know the opponent's most ambitious reply.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

c4 attacks d5 and may create a Réti or reversed Benoni structure where the g2 bishop and queenside pressure matter more than a kingside pawn storm.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Black gains space with ...d4 and uses the center to restrict White's knights.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White undermines the chain with e3, b4, or e4 and reroutes the displaced knight toward useful squares.

FAILURE MODE

Switching to c4 without accepting the strategic work required after ...d4.

DECISION TEST

Ask: If Black plays ...d4, what break attacks the chain's base and where will the b1 knight develop? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

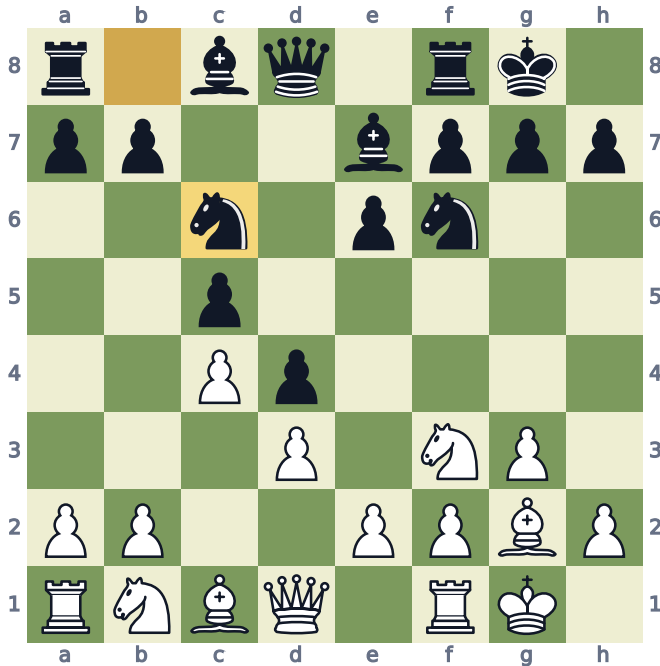
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. c4 c5 7. Nc3 d4 8. Nb1 Nc6



- c4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- c5: Black attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- d4: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess the chain, breaks, weak squares, and king exposure.
- Nb1: White reroutes a knight to b1; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

c4 attacks d5 and may create a Réti or reversed Benoni structure where the g2 bishop and queenside pressure matter more than a kingside pawn storm.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

If Black plays ...d4, what break attacks the chain's base and where will the b1 knight develop? White's attacking or positional plan is: White undermines the chain with e3, b4, or e4 and reroutes the displaced knight toward useful squares. The line fails as a template when: Switching to c4 without accepting the strategic work required after ...d4.

STORE THIS | A structural switch is good only when you know the opponent's most ambitious reply.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

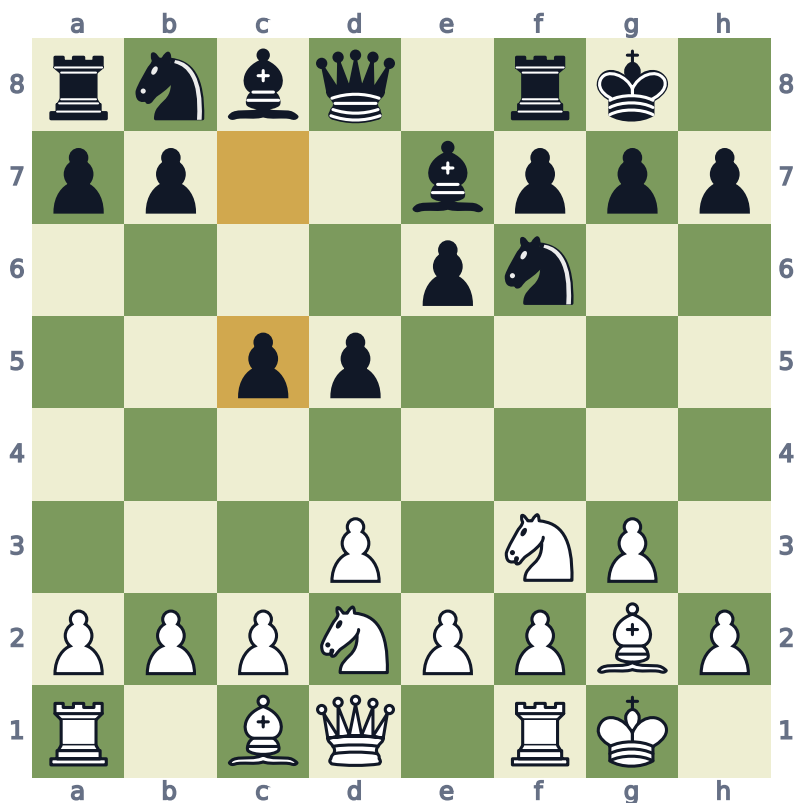
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. c4 c5 7. Nc3 d4 8. Nb1 Nc6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Opening with exd5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

When Black exchanges on e4, White's d-pawn recapture opens the d-file and frees the c1 bishop, but may leave an isolated or targetable e-pawn.

DECISION RULE

Which recapture activates more pieces, and what permanent pawn target does it create?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

Black exchanges pieces, pressures e4, and uses the d-file before White completes coordination.

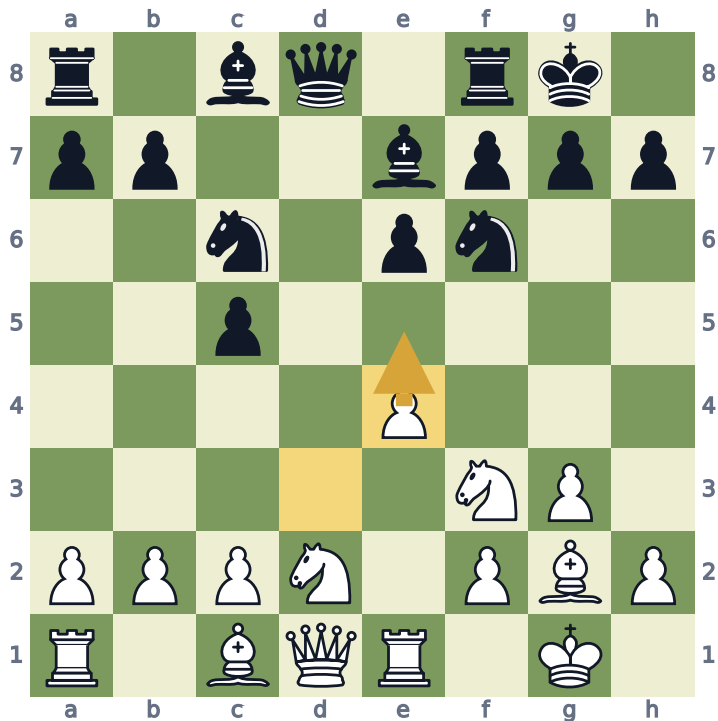
WHITE'S PLAN

White uses the open lines and development gain, accepting a different middlegame instead of rebuilding the closed KIA shell.

MEMORY RULE | When the center changes, keep the active recapture, not the old opening picture.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

White uses the open lines and development gain, accepting a different middlegame instead of rebuilding the closed KIA shell.

FAILURE MODE

Recapturing toward the familiar pawn shape while choosing the less active piece placement.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which recapture activates more pieces, and what permanent pawn target does it create? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

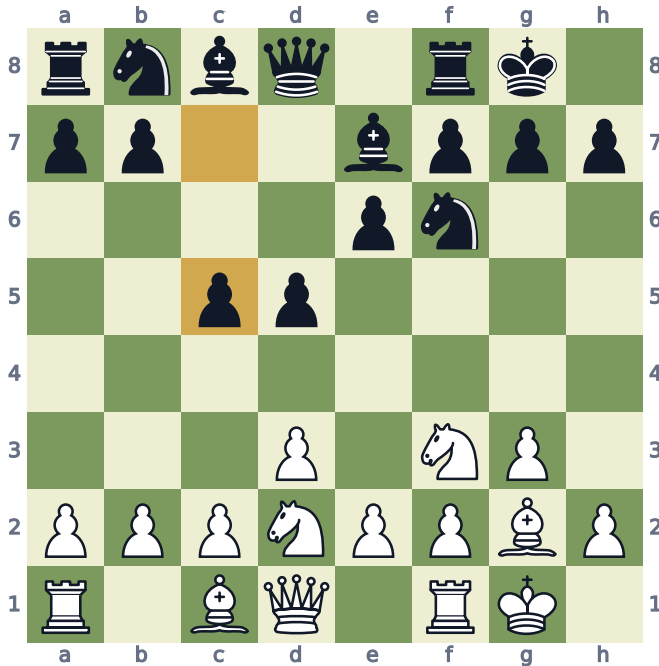
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1 dxe4 9. dxe4



- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the pawn break that will make the diagonal useful.
- d3: White supports e4 and keeps the center compact at the cost of space on d4.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the center can now close or open with less tactical risk.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- c5: Black attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

When Black exchanges on e4, White's d-pawn recapture opens the d-file and frees the c1 bishop, but may leave an isolated or targetable e-pawn.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which recapture activates more pieces, and what permanent pawn target does it create? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses the open lines and development gain, accepting a different middlegame instead of rebuilding the closed KIA shell. The line fails as a template when: Recapturing toward the familiar pawn shape while choosing the less active piece placement.

STORE THIS | When the center changes, keep the active recapture, not the old opening picture.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

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ANSWER KEY

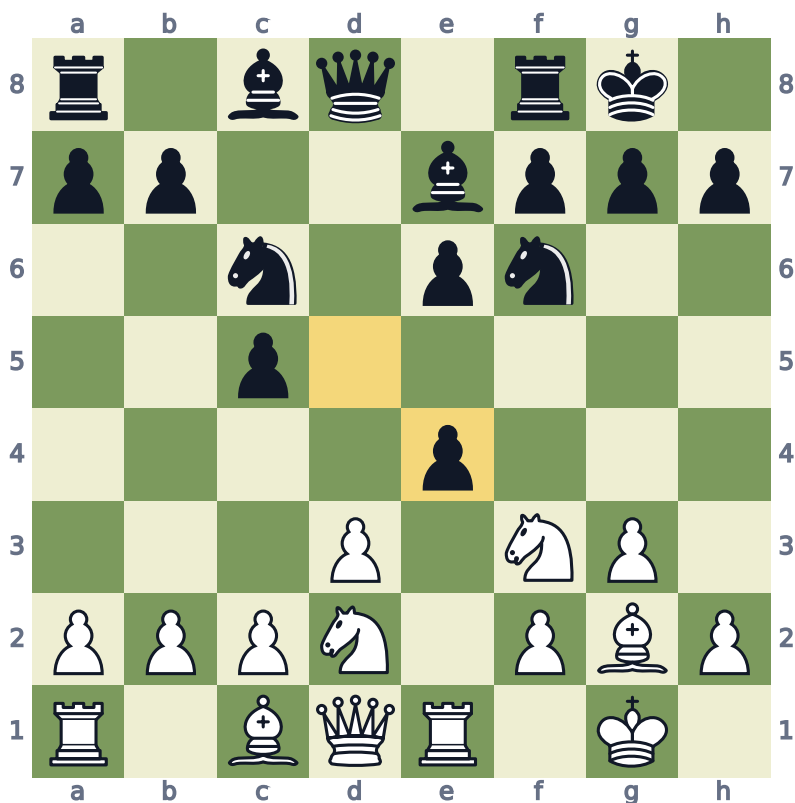
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 c5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Opening with exd5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

When Black exchanges on e4, White's d-pawn recapture opens the d-file and frees the c1 bishop, but may leave an isolated or targetable e-pawn.

DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S COUNTERPLAY

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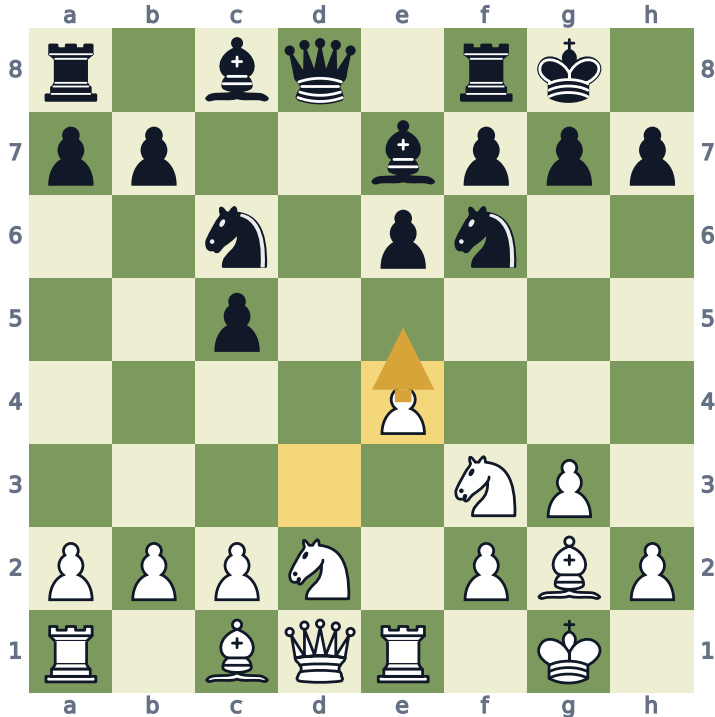
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL PLAN

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FAILURE MODE

Recapturing toward the familiar pawn shape while choosing the less active piece placement.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which recapture activates more pieces, and what permanent pawn target does it create? Then compare at least two White candidates against Black's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

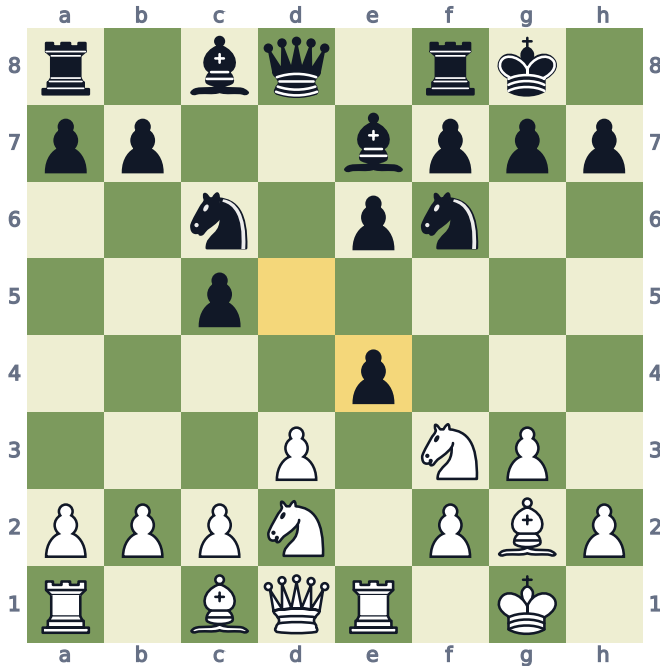
RULE | When the center changes, keep the active recapture, not the old opening picture.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1 dxe4 9. dxe4



- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- c5: Black attacks d4 and accelerates queenside expansion.
- e4: White builds the KIA center but must account for Black's immediate central break.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; name the destination job and the useful move conceded to the opponent.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a pawn break or file expected to open.
- dxe4: Black releases tension on e4; recalculate the pawn chain, open files, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

When Black exchanges on e4, White's d-pawn recapture opens the d-file and frees the c1 bishop, but may leave an isolated or targetable e-pawn.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which recapture activates more pieces, and what permanent pawn target does it create? White's attacking or positional plan is: White uses the open lines and development gain, accepting a different middlegame instead of rebuilding the closed KIA shell. The line fails as a template when: Recapturing toward the familiar pawn shape while choosing the less active piece placement.

STORE THIS | When the center changes, keep the active recapture, not the old opening picture.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's most urgent counterplay, and which pawn break enables it?

3. What is White's primary plan, and which piece or pawn makes it work?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. When Black exchanges on e4, White's d-pawn recapture opens the d-file and frees the c1 bishop, but may leave an isolated or targetable e-pawn. 2. Black exchanges pieces, pressures e4, and uses the d-file before White completes coordination. 3. White uses the open lines and development gain, accepting a different middlegame instead of rebuilding the closed KIA shell. 4. Which recapture activates more pieces, and what permanent pawn target does it create? 5. Recapturing toward the familiar pawn shape while choosing the less active piece placement.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1 dxe4

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 085 Decode: The c3-d4 transformation

Prompt: After d4, which pawn recapture keeps White's center coherent and which black piece gains a square?

Recall: Prepare a break by improving the position after every likely recapture.

LESSON 086 Play: The c3-d4 transformation

Prompt: After d4, which pawn recapture keeps White's center coherent and which black piece gains a square?

Recall: Prepare a break by improving the position after every likely recapture.

LESSON 087 Decode: Switching to c4 pressure

Prompt: If Black plays ...d4, what break attacks the chain's base and where will the b1 knight develop?

Recall: A structural switch is good only when you know the opponent's most ambitious reply.

LESSON 088 Play: Switching to c4 pressure

Prompt: If Black plays ...d4, what break attacks the chain's base and where will the b1 knight develop?

Recall: A structural switch is good only when you know the opponent's most ambitious reply.

LESSON 089 Decode: Opening with exd5

Prompt: Which recapture activates more pieces, and what permanent pawn target does it create?

Recall: When the center changes, keep the active recapture, not the old opening picture.

LESSON 090 Play: Opening with exd5

Prompt: Which recapture activates more pieces, and what permanent pawn target does it create?

Recall: When the center changes, keep the active recapture, not the old opening picture.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's counterplay, White's plan, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

The c3-d4 transformation

1. Nf3 d6 2. g3 e5 3. Bg2 Nf6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 Nc6 7. e4 Re8 8. c3 Bf8 9. Qc2 a5 10. d4

Decision: After d4, which pawn recapture keeps White's center coherent and which black piece gains a square?

Memory: Prepare a break by improving the position after every likely recapture.

CARD 2

Switching to c4 pressure

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. c4 c5 7. Nc3 d4 8. Nb1 Nc6

Decision: If Black plays ...d4, what break attacks the chain's base and where will the b1 knight develop?

Memory: A structural switch is good only when you know the opponent's most ambitious reply.

CARD 3

Opening with exd5

1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1 dxe4 9. dxe4

Decision: Which recapture activates more pieces, and what permanent pawn target does it create?

Memory: When the center changes, keep the active recapture, not the old opening picture.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
085 Decode: The c3-d4 transformation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
086 Play: The c3-d4 transformation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
087 Decode: Switching to c4 pressure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
088 Play: Switching to c4 pressure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
089 Decode: Opening with exd5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
090 Play: Opening with exd5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name Black's strongest counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.